UNILEVER

HUMAN RESOURCES POLICY HANDBOOK

20-PAGE DRAFT • PEOPLE, CULTURE & WORKPLACE STANDARDS

A practical framework for employees, people managers and HR teams

Prepared 21 October 2026

DOCUMENT STATUS: DRAFT TEMPLATE — NOT AN OFFICIAL UNILEVER PUBLICATION. This document was prepared on request as a customizable example. It has not been approved by Unilever, reviewed by its legal team, or verified against current internal policies. Adapt it to the relevant employing entity, country law, collective agreements and official brand standards before use.

Version 1.0 • Draft for review and localisation

How to Use This Handbook

Purpose and scope

This handbook brings together core people policies and operating standards in one reference. It is intended to support consistent, fair and respectful employment practices across teams while allowing local requirements to take precedence.

Before adoption

- Confirm the employing legal entity, countries and employee groups covered.
- Have local HR and employment counsel review statutory rights, consultation duties, works-council arrangements and collective agreements.
- Replace generic role titles, approval levels, systems, contacts and deadlines with approved internal details.
- Publish an accessible version and explain where employees can ask questions or raise concerns.

Policy hierarchy

Applicable law and binding collective agreements prevail over this template. Where a local rule grants a more favourable right, the local rule applies. Nothing in this draft removes any non-waivable legal right.

Accountability: HR owns policy maintenance; leaders are responsible for consistent implementation; employees are expected to read relevant policies and seek clarification when needed.

Employment Principles & Governance

Our people principles

The proposed framework is built around respect, integrity, safety, inclusion, accountability, consumer trust and responsible business conduct. Decisions should be evidence-based, explainable and free from retaliation or favouritism.

Policy ownership

Each policy should have a named owner, approving authority, effective date, review date and version number. HR should maintain a controlled source of truth and archive superseded versions.

Governance standards

- Apply policies consistently while considering reasonable accommodations and local context.
- Document material employment decisions and the business rationale for exceptions.
- Escalate conflicts between policies, law and local practice to HR and Legal before acting.
- Review policies at least annually and after material legal, organisational or operational changes.

Exceptions

Exceptions must be lawful, time-limited where appropriate, approved by the designated authority and recorded with rationale. An exception must not undermine safety, non-discrimination, privacy or employee rights.

Code of Conduct & Workplace Behaviour

Expected conduct

Employees are expected to act honestly, treat colleagues and third parties respectfully, protect company and consumer interests, use resources responsibly and comply with applicable laws and approved procedures.

Workplace standards

- Communicate professionally in person, in writing and on digital channels.
- Do not bully, harass, threaten, discriminate against or retaliate against another person.
- Avoid conflicts of interest or disclose them promptly through the designated process.
- Do not falsify records, misuse confidential information, or offer or accept improper benefits.
- Follow safety instructions and report hazards, misconduct or suspected legal breaches in good faith.

Speaking up

Concerns may be raised with a manager, HR, Ethics/Compliance or an approved confidential reporting channel. Reports should be handled promptly, fairly and as confidentially as practical.

Fair process

A concern is not proof of misconduct. Investigations should be impartial, proportionate, documented and respectful of the rights of all involved.

Hiring & Recruitment Policy

Purpose

Recruitment should identify capable people through a fair, consistent and job-related process. Hiring decisions must reflect role requirements and avoid discrimination, nepotism and unauthorised commitments.

Standard process

The hiring manager confirms business need, budget and an approved role profile. HR validates the requisition, advertises through approved channels, applies consistent screening criteria, coordinates structured interviews and documents the decision.

Selection controls

- Use role-related criteria and consistent core questions for comparable candidates.
- Provide reasonable adjustments during recruitment where required.
- Verify qualifications, references, work eligibility and other checks only as lawful and proportionate.
- Disclose relationships or conflicts that could affect impartiality.
- Do not promise compensation, title, start dates or employment terms without approval.

Offers and records

Written offers must be approved by the authorised function and specify material terms subject to local law. Candidate data should be accessed only by people with a legitimate hiring need and retained according to the privacy notice and retention schedule.

Onboarding, Probation & Employment Records

Before the start date

HR should confirm the signed agreement, right-to-work requirements, payroll details, required screening, equipment, system access and a named onboarding contact. Collect only information necessary for legitimate employment purposes.

First 90 days

Managers should provide a role overview, objectives, safety and conduct training, introductions, tools and regular check-ins. New employees should know how to access policies, benefits information, support channels and accommodations.

Probation

Where lawful and included in the employment terms, probation should have clear expectations, timely feedback and a documented review. Any extension or termination must be reviewed by HR and handled in accordance with contract and local law.

Recordkeeping

- Maintain accurate employment, pay, leave, training and performance records.
- Restrict access by role and use approved storage systems.
- Correct inaccurate records promptly and preserve records subject to legal holds.
- Follow local retention schedules and secure disposal requirements.

Leave & Time-Off Policy — Updated Sample Entitlements

Purpose and status

The figures in this section are proposed sample allowances for this customizable draft. They are not verified current Unilever benefits or official company policy. Before adoption, HR must confirm the employing country, local law, employment contracts and collective agreements.

Annual leave

25 working days of paid annual leave per full leave year for full-time employees. Prorate for part-time schedules and employees who join or leave during the year. Public holidays are separate where local law or approved policy provides. Carry-over, booking notice and payout on termination must follow local law and approved rules.

Maternity leave

Up to 26 weeks (approximately 6 months) of maternity leave, with pay and eligibility administered under the applicable country schedule. Where statutory rights are more generous, statutory rights apply. Employees should notify HR as early as reasonably practical. Pregnancy and medical information must be handled confidentially.

Requesting leave

Planned leave should be requested through the designated system with reasonable notice. Managers should respond promptly, consider operational coverage and apply criteria consistently. Emergency and statutory leave must be handled according to law; normal notice rules should not be used to deny protected leave.

Administration

HR/payroll should maintain accurate balances, explain eligibility and pay rules, and apply local rules for certification, accrual, carry-over, return-to-work and final pay. Employees should not be asked for unnecessary medical or sensitive details.

Local law and binding collective agreements take precedence. Insert country-specific rules before publication.

Additional proposed leave allowances

Leave type	Proposed allowance	Notes
Paternity / partner	10 working days	Per birth/adoption event; eligibility and pay subject to local rules.
Adoption	16 weeks primary parent; 10 days secondary parent	Confirm eligibility and local statutory entitlements.
Bereavement	5 days close family; 3 days extended family	Additional time may be considered.
Caregiver	5 working days per year	For urgent care of close family, where lawful.
Marriage / civil partnership	3 working days	For employee's own event, where lawful.
Study / examination	Up to 5 working days per year	Approved job-related qualifications; evidence may be required.

These allowances are illustrative proposals only, not confirmed Unilever policy. Verify statutory minimums, pay requirements, eligibility and overlaps before implementation.

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Volunteer leave: 2 working days paid per year for approved community volunteering, subject to business coverage and local rules. Sick leave: use country-specific statutory rules; pay, duration and certification vary by jurisdiction. Unpaid personal leave: up to 10 working days per year may be considered after paid leave is exhausted, subject to local law, operational needs and written approval.

Leave Schedule — Administration & Safeguards

Proposed sample allowances (continued)

Leave type	Proposed allowance	Administration
Volunteer leave	2 working days/year	Approved community volunteering; operational coverage applies.
Sick leave	Country-specific statutory rules	Follow local pay, duration, notice and certification requirements.
Unpaid personal leave	Up to 10 working days/year considered	After paid leave; written approval and local law apply.
Public holidays	According to local calendar/law	Treatment and pay depend on applicable local rules.

Request and approval process

1. Submit planned leave through the approved HR system with reasonable notice. 2. The manager responds promptly and applies consistent criteria. 3. HR/payroll confirms balances and pay treatment where needed. 4. Emergency leave should be reported as soon as reasonably possible. 5. Any denial, carry-over or exception should be documented and checked against law and company rules.

Privacy and protected leave

Handle health, pregnancy, family and other sensitive information on a need-to-know basis. Ask only for information necessary to administer the request lawfully. Do not disadvantage employees for taking statutory or protected leave, requesting reasonable accommodations or raising a good-faith concern.

Return to work

Where appropriate, HR and the employee should discuss return timing, any required restrictions, accommodations and support. Occupational health or qualified advice may be used where lawful and relevant. Keep medical details separate from routine manager communications where possible.

Localisation checklist

Before publishing, confirm: eligibility and pro-rating; maternity leave pay and benefits; partner/adoption entitlements; sick leave and medical certification; annual leave carry-over and termination payout; public holiday treatment; notice periods; payroll and tax implications; and any collective-agreement terms.

Policy hierarchy

Where local law, collective agreements or an employee's contract grants a more favourable mandatory entitlement, that entitlement takes precedence. Do not use the proposed sample figures to reduce a legal right.

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Compensation, Benefits & Payroll

Compensation principles

Pay decisions should be lawful, internally governed, market-informed and based on role scope, skills, experience and performance criteria. Pay practices should be reviewed for unexplained disparities and potential bias.

Payroll administration

Employees should provide accurate payroll information through approved secure channels. Payroll should issue accurate and timely payments, explain material deductions where required and provide a route to correct errors.

Benefits

Eligibility and coverage vary by location, employment category, plan terms and applicable law. HR should provide current plan documents and explain enrolment windows, dependants, exclusions, claims and appeal processes.

Controls

- Restrict access to salary and bank details.
- Require approval and audit trails for pay changes, bonuses and one-off payments.
- Handle overpayments or underpayments lawfully and transparently.
- Do not promise benefits outside approved plan terms.

Performance Management & Development

Performance cycle

Managers and employees should agree clear, measurable objectives aligned with team priorities. Expectations should cover outcomes, behaviours, collaboration, risk management and relevant professional standards.

Ongoing feedback

Feedback should be timely, specific, respectful and based on observable evidence. Regular check-ins should address progress, workload, obstacles, development interests and support needed.

Formal review

A periodic review should summarise achievements, agreed objectives, demonstrated behaviours and development priorities. Employees should have an opportunity to comment and correct factual inaccuracies. Calibration should improve consistency, not override evidence.

Performance concerns

- Clarify the gap and the expected standard.
- Offer reasonable support, coaching, resources and a fair opportunity to improve.
- Set proportionate goals and review dates, documenting discussions.
- Consult HR before formal warnings or adverse employment action.

Development

Learning may include coaching, mentoring, training, stretch assignments and career discussions. Access should be transparent and reasonably equitable.

Learning, Career Growth & Internal Mobility

Learning culture

Employees should complete mandatory training by the required deadlines and apply learning in their work. Managers should identify capability needs and make time for relevant development.

Training administration

Training records should identify the course, completion date and any renewal requirement. Safety, compliance, privacy and role-specific qualifications should be tracked through approved systems.

Internal opportunities

Vacancies and development assignments should be advertised or communicated through consistent processes where practicable. Selection should use job-related criteria, and employees should not be disadvantaged for raising concerns or taking protected leave.

Career conversations

- Discuss strengths, aspirations and realistic pathways.
- Agree development actions with owners and target dates.
- Avoid guarantees of promotion or role placement.
- Use succession planning responsibly and protect confidential talent information.

Diversity, Equity & Inclusion

Commitment

Every employee should be treated with dignity and have fair access to opportunity. The organisation should seek to remove unjustified barriers and foster a workplace where differences are respected.

Fair employment decisions

Recruitment, pay, learning, performance, promotion and separation decisions must be based on lawful, relevant criteria. Discrimination, harassment, victimisation and retaliation are prohibited.

Accessibility and accommodation

Employees and candidates should be able to request reasonable adjustments or accommodations through an accessible process. Requests should be handled respectfully, promptly and with appropriate confidentiality, subject to local law.

Inclusive practices

- Use accessible communications and inclusive meeting practices.
- Consider a range of perspectives in decision-making.
- Address inappropriate conduct promptly and consistently.
- Review people data lawfully to identify disparities while protecting privacy.
- Consult employee representatives or networks where appropriate.

Accountability

Leaders should model inclusive behaviour, respond to concerns and review outcomes. Good-faith reporting or participation in an investigation must not result in retaliation.

Respectful Workplace, Harassment & Grievances

Prohibited conduct

Harassment, bullying, sexual harassment, discrimination, intimidation and retaliation are not acceptable. Conduct may violate this policy even when described as humour or when it occurs through messages, social media or work-related events.

Raising a concern

Employees may raise concerns with a manager, HR, another designated leader or an approved reporting channel. If the concern involves the manager, an alternative route must be available.

Response process

The organisation should acknowledge concerns, assess immediate safety needs, select an impartial investigator where required, interview relevant people, review evidence and document findings. Interim measures should be proportionate and not punitive by default.

Grievance and appeal

Employees should be able to raise employment concerns without retaliation. Outcomes and any review or appeal route should be communicated to the extent appropriate and lawful.

Confidentiality is maintained on a need-to-know basis; absolute secrecy cannot be promised where a fair investigation or legal duty requires disclosure.

Health, Safety & Wellbeing

Shared responsibility

Everyone must take reasonable care for their own safety and the safety of others, follow site rules and report hazards, near misses, injuries and unsafe conditions promptly.

Management duties

Managers should provide appropriate risk assessments, training, protective equipment, emergency procedures and safe systems of work. Incidents should be investigated to prevent recurrence, not merely to assign blame.

Wellbeing

The organisation should encourage sustainable workloads, respectful management and access to relevant wellbeing resources. Employees are encouraged to seek support early. Wellbeing programmes do not replace clinical care or statutory duties.

Operational requirements

- Complete required safety inductions and refresher training.
- Do not work while impaired in a way that creates a safety risk.
- Follow emergency evacuation and incident-reporting procedures.
- Use ergonomic equipment and report hazards in office and remote settings.
- Consult occupational health or qualified specialists where appropriate and lawful.

Data Privacy, Confidentiality & Cybersecurity

Personal data

Personal data should be collected for defined, legitimate purposes, limited to what is necessary, kept accurate and retained only as long as required. Employees should receive applicable privacy notices and know how to exercise local rights.

Confidential information

Business plans, employee records, product information, customer data, trade secrets and non-public financial information must be handled according to classification and access rules.

Security practices

Use approved systems, strong authentication, secure storage and authorised sharing methods. Report suspected phishing, loss of devices, unauthorised access or data disclosure promptly through the security incident channel.

Prohibited practices

- Do not share credentials or bypass security controls.
- Do not transfer company data to personal accounts or unapproved tools.
- Do not access records without a business need.
- Do not retain company information after authorisation ends, except as legally required.

Monitoring

Any workplace monitoring must have a lawful basis, be proportionate and transparent, and follow applicable notice, consultation and privacy requirements.

Ethics, Conflicts of Interest & Whistleblowing

Ethical decisions

Employees must comply with applicable law and approved standards on anti-bribery, fraud prevention, fair competition, sanctions, gifts and hospitality, and accurate books and records.

Conflicts of interest

A conflict may arise from outside employment, financial interests, close personal relationships, supplier arrangements or decisions affecting someone with whom an employee has a personal connection. Disclose actual, potential or perceived conflicts promptly.

Gifts and hospitality

Only accept or offer items permitted by the applicable standard and approval limits. Never use gifts, payments or favours to improperly influence a decision. Record approvals as required.

Speak-up protection

Good-faith reports should be taken seriously. Retaliation against a person who raises a concern, assists an investigation or refuses improper conduct is prohibited. Knowingly malicious reports may be addressed through a fair process.

Escalation

Use approved Ethics/Compliance channels for suspected corruption, fraud, competition-law concerns or serious misconduct. Preserve relevant records and do not conduct unauthorised investigations.

Technology, AI & Acceptable Use

Acceptable use

Company technology should be used lawfully, securely and primarily for authorised business purposes. Limited personal use may be permitted by local rules if it does not create risk, cost or disruption.

Generative AI and automated tools

Use only tools approved for the relevant data and task. Do not enter confidential, personal, regulated or commercially sensitive information into unapproved systems. Human review is required for consequential decisions and factual outputs.

Quality and accountability

Employees remain responsible for work produced with digital tools. Verify accuracy, licensing, bias, privacy, security and suitability before relying on or publishing output.

Required practices

- Use licensed software and approved collaboration platforms.
- Report suspected compromise or unauthorised software promptly.
- Do not create deceptive, discriminatory or harmful content using company tools.
- Follow records, retention and legal-hold requirements.
- Do not use automated scoring or monitoring for employment decisions without formal approval and appropriate safeguards.

Travel, Expenses & Procurement Conduct

Business travel

Travel should have a legitimate business purpose, be approved at the appropriate level and use approved booking channels where required. Employees should consider safety, accessibility, environmental impact and cost.

Expenses

Claim only reasonable, necessary and properly evidenced business expenses. Submit claims within local deadlines and identify personal portions clearly. Altered receipts, duplicate claims and fabricated expenses are prohibited.

Procurement integrity

Supplier selection should be fair, documented and based on business need, quality, value, sustainability and risk. Follow sourcing thresholds, due diligence, segregation of duties and contract approval requirements.

Controls

- Obtain approval before committing company funds.
- Disclose supplier relationships or personal interests.
- Do not split purchases to evade approval limits.
- Protect supplier confidential information and compete fairly.
- Escalate suspected fraud, sanctions or human-rights risks.

Family, Medical & Other Protected Leave; Accommodations

Supportive administration

Requests involving pregnancy, parental responsibilities, disability, medical needs, religion, caregiving or other protected circumstances should be handled with dignity and in line with applicable law.

Medical information

Managers should not request more medical detail than necessary to administer a lawful process. Sensitive information should be restricted to authorised personnel and shared only where needed.

Return to work

Where appropriate, HR and the employee should discuss a safe and practical return, any required restrictions, accommodations and a review date. Decisions should be based on relevant evidence and legal obligations.

Flexible arrangements

Temporary or ongoing changes to duties, hours, location or equipment may be considered as an accommodation where appropriate. Evaluate each request individually, document the decision and revisit arrangements when circumstances change.

This section is not a substitute for country-specific guidance on statutory family leave, disability rights, medical certification or occupational health.

Discipline, Investigations, Separation & Policy Administration

Fair and proportionate action

Where misconduct or serious performance concerns arise, establish relevant facts, give the employee a reasonable opportunity to respond, and consider consistency, context, prior history and applicable law. Depending on severity and local requirements, action may range from coaching and warnings to termination. Any precautionary measure must be lawful, proportionate and reviewed.

Investigations and separation

Investigators should be impartial, protect evidence, maintain appropriate confidentiality and avoid prejudging outcomes. Employees should cooperate honestly and may have representation or accompaniment rights where applicable. Notice, final pay, accrued leave, benefits, consultation, redundancy and other obligations vary by jurisdiction and contract; HR and Legal should review involuntary separations before action.

Offboarding checklist

• Confirm decision authority and required notices. • Recover equipment and revoke access at the appropriate time. • Provide final payroll and benefits information. • Preserve records subject to retention rules and legal holds. • Conduct an exit process where appropriate and protect employee dignity.

Questions, review and change control

Employees should contact their manager or HR for routine questions. Sensitive concerns may be raised through an alternative reporting route or Ethics/Compliance channel. The policy owner should review the handbook at least annually and after material legal, operational or risk changes. Updates must be approved, version-controlled, communicated and translated where necessary.

Local annexes to complete before publication

Attach country-specific schedules for leave entitlements, working time, pay practices, benefits, data privacy, consultation and representation, safety contacts, reporting channels and statutory notices. Applicable law and binding collective agreements take precedence over this template.

Employee acknowledgement

I acknowledge that I have received or been given access to the applicable HR policy handbook, understand that I am responsible for reading relevant policies, and know where to seek clarification. This acknowledgement does not waive statutory or contractual rights.

Employee name: _____ Signature: _____

Date: _____ Country / employing entity: _____

Approval record: Policy owner: HR | Approver: _____ | Version: 1.0 draft

Effective date: | Next review:

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